

ZAWADI AFRICA EDUCATION FUND

College Access Platform

10-Week Project Build Handout

Duration 10 Weeks	Team 1–2 Developers	Target Users Students & Mentors	Program Zawadi Africa
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1. Project Overview

The Zawadi Africa Education Fund helps Kenyan girls from low-income backgrounds navigate the college application process for institutions abroad. Currently, the program has a rich set of resources — essay writing guides, SAT prep materials, recommendation letter tips, and financial aid walkthroughs — but these are scattered across multiple locations, making it difficult for students and mentors to track progress and stay organized.

This project is to build a unified web platform that centralizes all these resources under one roof, with dedicated sections for each part of the application journey. The platform will serve two distinct user types: students, who access resources and practice their skills, and mentors, who track progress, review work, and give feedback.

1.1 Primary Goals

- Unify scattered resources into a single, easy-to-navigate platform
- Provide a structured essay writing workspace for students with mentor review functionality
- Deliver a comprehensive SAT prep environment including links to Khan Academy, practice exams, and mini-problem drills
- Include guidance sections for recommendation letters and financial aid (CSS Profile)
- Build a role-based system distinguishing student and mentor experiences

1.2 What This Platform Is NOT

- It is not a content creation project — resources already exist and will be organized, linked, or embedded
- It is not replacing Khan Academy — it will link out to Khan Academy for SAT topic courses
- It is not a full Learning Management System (LMS) — it is focused and purpose-built for Zawadi's specific workflow

2. Platform Architecture & Sections

The platform will be organized into four main sections plus a shared dashboard accessible by both students and mentors.

Section 1 — Essay Writing

- Sub-sections: Personal Statement & Supplemental Essays
- Students: Access writing resources, write and submit essays, receive mentor feedback
- Mentors: View all student essays, track revision history, leave comments and feedback
- Resource library: uploaded guides, sample essays, video walkthroughs
- First-time diagnostic essay to establish baseline for new students

Section 2 — SAT Preparation

- Links to Khan Academy courses organized by SAT topic (Reading, Writing, Math)
- Full-length practice exams modelled after the actual SAT format
- Mini-problems / flashcard-style drills for quick practice
- Mentor view: dashboard showing student scores and areas of difficulty
- Optional future feature: AI-powered recommendations based on performance patterns

Section 3 — Recommendation Letters

- Guide on how and when to approach potential recommenders
- Tips for writing a stellar self-drafted recommendation letter
- Template library and annotated examples
- Checklist: follow-up timelines and what to send to recommenders

Section 4 — Financial Aid (CSS Profile)

- Step-by-step walkthrough of the CSS Profile form
- Explanations of each section and what information to gather
- FAQs specific to Kenyan students (currency, tax systems, etc.)
- Links to any existing Zawadi-created financial aid resources

3. User Roles & Permissions

Feature	Student	Mentor
Access resources & guides	✓	✓
Write and submit essays	✓	—
View own essays & feedback	✓	—
Review all student essays	—	✓
Leave essay comments/feedback	—	✓
Track student progress	—	✓
Access SAT practice exams	✓	—
View student SAT scores	—	✓
Complete mini-problems/drills	✓	—
Access all student dashboards	—	✓

4. Recommended Technology Stack

The following is a recommended stack. You should adjust based on your existing familiarity and any tools you are already using.

Layer	Recommendation	Rationale
Frontend	React.js + Tailwind CSS	Fast, component-based; great for dashboards
Backend	Node.js + Express OR Firebase	Firebase saves setup time with auth + database built in
Database	Firestore (Firebase) OR PostgreSQL	Firestore is quick to launch; PostgreSQL for more complex queries
Authentication	Firebase Auth	Role-based auth (student vs mentor) out of the box
File Storage	Firebase Storage or AWS S3	For uploaded essays and resource documents
Hosting	Vercel or Netlify (frontend), Railway (backend)	Free tiers sufficient for program scale
Rich Text Editor	TipTap or Quill.js	For essay writing with formatting support

5. 10-Week Project Plan

The plan is organized into three phases. Each week has defined goals and concrete deliverables. Weeks are designed to be achievable for a 1–2 person team working part-time (roughly 10–15 hours per week).

PHASE 1 Foundation & Setup (Weeks 1–2)

WEEK 1 — Project Foundation

🎯 Goals This Week	✅ Deliverables
• Define final feature scope and confirm tech stack • Set up version control (GitHub repository) • Initialize frontend project (React + Tailwind) • Initialize backend / Firebase project • Design information architecture (sitemap) • Audit all existing Zawadi resources and categorize them	• GitHub repository live and organized • Project folder structure created • Resource audit spreadsheet (list of all existing materials by section) • Sitemap / wireframe sketch of all pages
🏁 Milestone: Foundation is set — you know exactly what you're building and what you have	

WEEK 2 — Authentication & Navigation Shell

🎯 Goals This Week	✅ Deliverables
• Implement user authentication (login, register, role assignment) • Build the main navigation shell (sidebar or top nav) • Create student dashboard skeleton • Create mentor dashboard skeleton • Set up routing between sections • Deploy a 'hello world' version to hosting platform	• Working login / register flow with two roles (student, mentor) • Navigation shell with placeholders for all four sections • Live deployment URL (staging environment) • Student and mentor dashboards visible (empty but accessible)
🏁 Milestone: Platform skeleton is live — you can log in and navigate	

PHASE 2 Core Feature Development (Weeks 3–7)

WEEK 3 — Essay Section — Student Experience

🎯 Goals This Week	✅ Deliverables
• Build Personal Statement sub-section page • Build Supplemental Essays sub-section page • Integrate rich text editor for essay writing • Build essay submission flow (save draft, submit for review) • Create resource library page — upload/embed existing essay guides	• Students can write, save drafts, and submit essays • Diagnostic essay prompt displayed for new students • Resource library with existing Zawadi materials accessible

- Build diagnostic essay prompt for first-time students

- Personal Statement and Supplemental Essay sub-sections navigable

WEEK 4 — Essay Section — Mentor Experience

🎯 Goals This Week	✅ Deliverables
• Build mentor essay review dashboard (list of all submitted essays) • Implement inline commenting / feedback on essays • Build essay status tracking (Submitted, Under Review, Feedback Given, Revised) • Implement student progress view for mentors (essays written, revisions made) • Email or in-app notification when feedback is given	• Mentors can view all student essays in one dashboard • Mentors can leave inline comments and overall feedback • Essay status updates visibly tracked • Mentor progress dashboard functional
🏁 Milestone: Essay module fully functional for both students and mentors	

WEEK 5 — SAT Prep — Khan Academy Links & Mini-Problems

🎯 Goals This Week	✅ Deliverables
• Build SAT Prep section page with topic navigation • Organize and embed Khan Academy links by SAT topic (Reading, Writing, Math No Calculator, Math Calculator) • Build mini-problems / flashcard interface • Create or import initial set of mini-problems (can pull from existing resources) • Track which mini-problems a student has completed	• SAT Prep section live with Khan Academy links organized by topic • Flashcard/mini-problem UI functional with at least 20 problems per topic • Student completion tracking for mini-problems working

WEEK 6 — SAT Prep — Practice Exams

🎯 Goals This Week	✅ Deliverables
• Design practice exam structure (mirroring actual SAT sections) • Build exam-taking interface (timer, section navigation, answer selection) • Build auto-scoring and results display • Store exam results per student • Build mentor view: SAT scores and performance trends by student	• At least one full-length practice exam live and takeable • Exam results saved and displayed to students • Mentor dashboard shows each student's exam scores and trends
🏁 Milestone: SAT Prep module fully functional	

WEEK 7 — Recommendation Letters & Financial Aid Sections

🎯 Goals This Week	✅ Deliverables
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- Build Recommendation Letters section
- Embed or link existing Zawadi recommendation letter guides
- Add tips for self-drafting recommendation letters and templates
- Add recommender approach guide and checklist
- Build Financial Aid section
- Create or embed step-by-step CSS Profile walkthrough
- Add Kenya-specific FAQ (currency, tax documentation, etc.)

- Recommendation Letters section fully built with guides and templates
- Financial Aid section fully built with CSS walkthrough
- All existing Zawadi content for these sections integrated

🏁 **Milestone: All four content sections are live**

PHASE 3 Polish, Testing & Launch (Weeks 8–10)

WEEK 8 — Integration, Testing & Bug Fixes

🎯 Goals This Week	✅ Deliverables
• End-to-end testing of all user flows (student and mentor) • Fix bugs identified during testing • Ensure mobile responsiveness across all pages • Test all Khan Academy links and external resources • Review all uploaded content for accuracy and completeness • Performance testing (ensure pages load quickly on slower connections)	• Bug fix log documented and resolved • Platform fully functional on mobile and desktop • All resource links verified working • Performance benchmarks met

WEEK 9 — User Feedback & Iteration

🎯 Goals This Week	✅ Deliverables
• Conduct a pilot test with 2–3 real students and 1 mentor • Collect structured feedback (short questionnaire) • Prioritize and implement top feedback items • Write user onboarding guides (how to use the platform) • Finalize all copy, labels, and instructional text on the platform • Review all section content with Zawadi program coordinator	• Pilot test completed with real users • Feedback documented and top items addressed • Onboarding guide (PDF or in-app walkthrough) complete • All section content reviewed and approved

WEEK 10 — Launch & Handover

🎯 Goals This Week	✅ Deliverables
• Final round of testing post-iteration	• Platform live on production domain • Admin and mentor setup guide complete

- Set up production environment (separate from staging)
- Configure domain name and SSL
- Create admin / mentor account setup guide
- Create student onboarding flow (first login experience)
- Document codebase and platform for future developers
- Official launch

- Student onboarding flow tested and live
- Technical documentation for the codebase
- Post-launch monitoring in place

🚩 **Milestone: Platform is live — Zawadi students can start using it**

6. Milestone Summary

Week	Milestone	What It Means
1	Resource audit complete	You know exactly what content you have and where it goes
2	Platform skeleton live	Anyone can register and log in with the right role
4	Essay module complete	Students can write essays; mentors can review and give feedback
6	SAT module complete	Full SAT prep functionality available to students
7	All four sections live	Every part of the platform has content and is navigable
9	Pilot test done	Real user feedback incorporated; platform refined
10	LAUNCH	Platform is production-ready and accessible to all Zawadi students

7. Risks, Notes & Future Features

7.1 Key Risks to Watch

- Scope creep: It can be tempting to keep adding features. Stick to the four core sections first and defer extras to a v2.
- Content bottleneck: The platform needs existing Zawadi resources to be uploaded and organized. Ensure someone is assigned to gather and hand over all content by the end of Week 1.
- Internet connectivity: Kenyan students may have limited or slow internet access. Keep the platform lightweight; avoid large uncompressed media files.
- User adoption: A beautiful platform is worthless if students don't use it. The pilot in Week 9 is critical — use it seriously.

7.2 Features Deferred to Future Versions

- AI-powered SAT recommendations based on past performance (can be added in v2 using Claude or OpenAI API)
- Universities outside the US — a fifth section covering UK, Canada, and other destinations
- In-app messaging between students and mentors
- Automated reminders and deadline tracking for college application dates
- Progress certificates or badges for students who complete sections

7.3 Important Decisions to Make Early

1. Will you use Firebase (simpler setup) or a custom backend (more flexible)? Decide this in Week 1.
2. Who is responsible for uploading and maintaining content? Assign a program coordinator role.
3. How will new students be added? Will there be a self-registration flow or will mentors create accounts for students?
4. What devices will students primarily use? If mostly mobile, prioritize mobile design from Day 1.

This platform will be a significant asset for Zawadi students.

10 weeks. 4 sections. One unified experience for girls who deserve every advantage.